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Lead technical architect, AI Centre of Excellence (up to £95,278)

Department for Education

Apply before 11:55 pm on Sunday 5th July 2026



Department
for Education

Reference number

467663

Salary

£70,854

National pay band minimum = £70,854. London pay band minimum = £74,528.

This post is eligible for a Digital, Data and Technology (DDT) capability based pay (CBP) allowance.

This is a discretionary non-consolidated, non-pensionable allowance which, if awarded, is attached to the post. The value of the allowance is based on the outcome of a capability assessment and is reviewed annually.

Allowance values range up to £20,750, with the highest values reserved for candidates whose capability is above the expected level for all of the skills.

A Civil Service Pension with an employer contribution of 28.97%

Job grade

Grade 6

Contract type

Permanent

Business area

DFE - Digital and Infrastructure Group

Type of role

Architecture and Data

Digital

Information Technology

Working pattern

Flexible working, Full-time, Job share, Part-time

Number of jobs available

1

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Location

Coventry, West Midlands (England), CV1 2WT : Darlington, North East England, DL1 5QE : Manchester, North West England, M1 2WD : Sheffield, Yorkshire and the Humber, S1 2FJ : City of Westminster, London (region), SW1P 3BT

About the job

Job summary

As a lead technical architect, you will be designing and building AI-based products and services for a diverse set of internal and external users.

The Department for Education (DfE) have developed an AI Centre of Excellence (CoE) to facilitate the adoption of AI across the DfE. The objectives of the CoE are:

1. To facilitate the delivery of AI projects and tools.
2. Develop and maintain the core technologies and platforms for AI.
3. To provide guidance and advice for the secure development and use of AI technologies.
4. To build skills and capability for the effective development and use of AI technologies.
5. To have oversight of all AI projects within the Department for effective assurance and reporting.

There is a need to support the ongoing development of the CoE service for building and integrating AI solutions into DfE products and services.

The post holder will develop designs and patterns for AI use cases, develop and publish standards, and provide technical guidance for delivery of AI work across the DfE. This will involve engagement both within the CoE and across teams in the Department, to ensure the safe and effective development and use of AI technologies.

To enable delivery of new products, the postholder will also help shape data strategy and lead complex technical projects by effectively using data to uncover insights, build models and support decision-making for AI use cases.

Job description

Your main responsibilities will include:

Designing and maintaining the AI CoE service and products - keeping up to date with the latest technologies, whilst delivering software early and often.

Leading technical specialists across multiple AI projects and services, on problems that require broad architectural thinking.

The development of designs, patterns and technical guidance for new AI use cases

Using data to uncover insights, build models, and support decision-making for AI use cases

Defining how to build and operate user-centred, open-source web systems in an agile environment, to serve a variety of citizen and government needs.

Being responsible for the technical design and development of AI products and services, including how they interact with their surroundings, and how they evolve over time.

Challenging entrenched practices and influencing decision-makers, looking for deeper underlying problems to solve, and larger opportunities for digital transformation (including AI and productivity).

Communicating the vision for the AI CoE and AI services to developers and non-developers alike, working in multi-disciplinary teams that bring policy and delivery together.

Playing an active role in the DfE Technical Architecture community, where you will share knowledge of tools and techniques, as well as joining related communities of practice and events where appropriate, such as product, user research, design, platforms, security, etc.

Helping to build a diverse, inclusive culture across the technical architecture community.

Person specification

Essential Criteria:

Assessed in application and both interview stages experience in:

Leading multidisciplinary teams to design and deliver AI-enabled, user-centred services in an agile environment.

Establishing engineering practices for AI systems, including TDD, CI/CD, automated deployment, model lifecycle management, version control (Git) and DevOps.

Designing and assuring scalable, secure, cloud-based AI architectures, including data platforms, model hosting and integration patterns.

Software development experience building production AI systems, including .NET and Python, developing and integrating ML/GenAI components via APIs, and applying testing, security and observability practices.

Knowledge of open-source principles and technologies.

Assessed in application and second interview stage:

Ability to build consensus between diverse and often conflicting interests, working with technical and non-technical stakeholders to achieve agreement on AI architectures, standards and patterns.

Ability to take a strategic, whole-system view of AI solutions, considering data, platforms, integration, governance and long-term sustainability.

Practical understanding of end-to-end technical architecture, from front-end and APIs, to data pipelines, model layers, infrastructure and networking.

The following criteria are **desirable**. Applicant's evidence against these criteria will be used at interview in the event of a tie break situation, to make an informed decision:

Experience implementing automated testing and evaluation for AI systems (e.g. model validation, prompt evaluation, continuous assurance).

Experience applying the UK Government Service Standard, Technology Code of Practice, and secure-by-design principles.

Experience mentoring and developing AI engineering and architecture capability in multidisciplinary teams.

Ability to work with stakeholders to produce effective strategies for technology choices, using the most appropriate languages, frameworks and tools to meet user and business needs.

Benefits

Alongside your salary of £70,854, Department for Education contributes £20,526 towards you being a member of the Civil Service Defined Benefit Pension scheme. [Find out what benefits a Civil Service Pension provides \(opens in a new window\)](#).

Applicants currently holding a permanent post in the Civil Service should note that, if successful, their salary on appointment would be determined by the Department's transfer / promotion policies.

As a member of the DfE, you will be entitled to join the highly competitive Civil Service Pension Scheme, which many experts agree is one of the most generous in the UK.

You will have 25 days leave, increasing by 1 day every year to a maximum of 30 days after five years' service. In addition, all staff receive the King's Birthday privilege holiday and 8 days' bank and public holidays.

We offer flexible working arrangements, such as job sharing, term-time working, flexi-time and compressed hours.

Most DfE employees will be working a hybrid pattern, spending at least 60% of their time in an office or work setting. Changes to these working

arrangements are available in exceptional circumstances but must be agreed with the line manager and in line with the requirements of the role.

Travel to your primary office location will not be paid for by DfE, but costs for travel to an office which is not your main location will be covered.

As an organisation, which exists to support education and lifelong learning, we offer our staff excellent professional development opportunities.

Things you need to know

Artificial intelligence

Artificial intelligence can be a useful tool to support your application, however, all examples and statements provided must be truthful, factually accurate and taken directly from your own experience. Where plagiarism has been identified (presenting the ideas and experiences of others, or generated by artificial intelligence, as your own) applications may be withdrawn and internal candidates may be subject to disciplinary action. Please see our [candidate guidance \(opens in a new window\)](#) for more information on appropriate and inappropriate use.

Selection process details

Application/sift:

At application you will be asked to provide your CV and a statement of suitability. Both should be anonymised (all personal information removed, such as your name, date of birth, gender, contact information, nationality etc).

Your CV should include details of previous roles held and responsibilities / previous skills and experience.

Your statement of suitability (max 1250 words) should demonstrate how you meet the essential criteria listed in the person specification section above.

Your CV and statement will be assessed together against the listed essential criteria.

First stage interview:

Longlisted candidates may be invited to attend a preliminary interview, typically involving a commitment of up to 1 hour.

The interview will consist of a series of questions to further assess the essential criteria for the role, focused on the first five essential criteria.

Interviews will be on MS teams, which may be remote or from a DfE office - we will confirm which when you are invited to an interview.

If successful, candidates will then be invited to a second interview.

Second stage interview:

At this interview we will ask questions to further assess your experience in relation to all of the listed essential criteria.

This will be used to assess your experience against the essential (and in the case of a tie, the desirable) criteria.

Interviews will be on MS teams, which may be remote or from a DfE office - we will confirm which when you are invited to an interview.

Feedback

Feedback will only be provided if you attend an interview.

Timing

We expect to sift in week commencing 13 July 2026

First stage interviews will likely take place in the week commencing 27 July 2026.

Second stage interviews will likely take place in the week commencing 10 August 2026.

Once a provisional offer has been made, you will be invited to participate in a capability assessment to determine the value of the CBP allowance we can offer you. The assessment compares your skills against the Lead Technical

Architect role described in DfE's local Technical Architecture Capability Framework, which is based on the Government Digital and Data Profession Capability Framework.

Subject to your availability, we will aim to conduct the capability assessment and confirm the allowance offer to you within a week of the provisional offer being made.

This is a discretionary non-consolidated, non-pensionable allowance which, if awarded, is attached to the post. The value of the allowance is based on the outcome of a capability assessment and is reviewed annually. Allowance values range up to £20,750, with the highest values reserved for candidates whose capability is above the expected level for all of the skills.

Other Information

Interviews may be via Microsoft teams or face to face; the vacancy manager will confirm prior to the Interview.

In your application, please don't include personal information that identifies you.

This means we can recruit based on your knowledge and skills, and not background, gender or ethnicity - it's called name blind recruitment (opens in a new window).

Please ensure that you remove from your application, all references to your:

name/title

educational institutions

age

gender

email address

postal address

phone number

nationality/immigration status

We reserve the right to raise the minimum pass mark in the event of a high volume or strong field of candidates.

Please be aware that this role can only be worked in the UK from the location options provided and not from overseas.

The government is committed to supporting apprenticeships, enabling people to learn and progress in a role whilst earning. We want to monitor the number of people who have completed apprenticeships who are now applying to progress further in their career and are asking this question to all candidates, on all vacancies. You will be asked a question as part of the application process about any previous apprenticeships you have completed. Your response to this question will not affect your application and it is not a requirement of the role to have completed a previous apprenticeship.

If successful and transferring from another Government Department a criminal record check maybe carried out.

In order to process applications without delay, we will be sending a Criminal Record Check to Disclosure and Barring Service on your behalf. However, we recognise in exceptional circumstance some candidates will want to send their completed forms direct. If you will be doing this, please advise Department of Education of your intention by emailing Pre-Employment.Checks.DFE@education.gov.uk stating the job reference number in the subject heading.

Department for Education do not cover the cost of travel to your interview/assessment unless otherwise stated.

A reserve list may be held for a period of 12 months from which further appointments can be made.

Candidates will be posted in merit order based upon location preference. Where more than one location is advertised you will be asked to state your preferred location.

New entrants are expected to join on the minimum of the pay band.

Applicants who are successful at interview will be, as part of pre-employment screening subject to a check on the Internal Fraud Database (IFD). This

check will provide information about employees who have been dismissed for fraud or dishonesty offences. This check also applies to employees who resign or otherwise leave before being dismissed for fraud or dishonesty had their employment continued. Any applicant's details held on the IFD will be refused employment.

Terms and conditions of candidates transferring from ALBs and NDPBs

Bodies that are not accredited by the Civil Service Commission and are not able to advertise at Across Government on Civil Service jobs will be treated as external new starters and will come into DfE on modernised terms and conditions with a salary at the band minimum.

Bodies that are accredited by the Civil Service Commission but do not have civil service status will be offered modernised terms and will not have continuous service recognised for leave or sickness benefits. Salaries should be offered at band minimum, but there is some flexibility where this would cause a detriment to the individual.

Bodies that are accredited by the Civil Service Commission and do have Civil Service status will be treated as OGD transfers. Staff appointed on lateral transfer will move on to pre-modernised DfE terms (unless they were on modernised terms in their previous organisation). Staff appointed on promotion will move on to modernised DfE terms. Staff will transfer over on their existing salary (on lateral transfer) and any pay above the DfE pay band maximum will be paid as a mark time allowance. Staff moving on promotion will have their salaries calculated using the principles set out in the attached OGD transfer supplementary information.

Reasonable adjustment

If a person with disabilities is put at a substantial disadvantage compared to a non-disabled person, we have a duty to make reasonable changes to our processes. If you need a change to be made so that you can make your application, you should:

Contact Department of Education
via centralrecruitment.operations@education.gov.uk soon as possible
before the closing date to discuss your needs.

Complete the Assistance required section in the Additional requirements page of your application form to tell us what changes or help you might need further on in the recruitment process. For instance, you may need wheelchair access at interview, or if you're deaf, a Language Service Professional.

Please refer to the attached Reasonable Adjustments Guide 05_2025 accessible version at the bottom of the advert, for further information.

Childcare Vouchers

Any move to Department for Education (DfE) will mean you will no longer be able to carry on claiming childcare vouchers. This includes moves between government departments. You may however be eligible for other government schemes, including Tax-Free Childcare. Determine your eligibility at <https://www.childcarechoices.gov.uk/>

Feedback will only be provided if you attend an interview or assessment.

Security

Successful candidates must undergo a criminal record check.

People working with government assets must complete [baseline personnel security standard \(opens in new window\)](#) checks.

Nationality requirements

This job is broadly open to the following groups:

- UK nationals

- nationals of the Republic of Ireland

- nationals of Commonwealth countries who have the right to work in the UK

- nationals of the EU, Switzerland, Norway, Iceland or Liechtenstein and family members of those nationalities with settled or pre-settled status under the [European Union Settlement Scheme \(EUSS\) \(opens in a new window\)](#)

nationals of the EU, Switzerland, Norway, Iceland or Liechtenstein and family members of those nationalities who have made a valid application for settled or pre-settled status under the European Union Settlement Scheme (EUSS)

individuals with limited leave to remain or indefinite leave to remain who were eligible to apply for EUSS on or before 31 December 2020

Turkish nationals, and certain family members of Turkish nationals, who have accrued the right to work in the Civil Service

[Further information on nationality requirements \(opens in a new window\)](#)

Working for the Civil Service

The [Civil Service Code \(opens in a new window\)](#) sets out the standards of behaviour expected of civil servants.

We recruit by merit on the basis of fair and open competition, as outlined in the Civil Service Commission's [recruitment principles \(opens in a new window\)](#).

The Civil Service embraces diversity and promotes equal opportunities. As such, we run a Disability Confident Scheme (DCS) for candidates with disabilities who meet the minimum selection criteria.

The Civil Service also offers a Redeployment Interview Scheme to civil servants who are at risk of redundancy, and who meet the minimum requirements for the advertised vacancy.

Diversity and Inclusion

The Civil Service is committed to attract, retain and invest in talent wherever it is found. To learn more please see the [Civil Service People Plan \(opens in a new window\)](#) and the [Civil Service Diversity and Inclusion Strategy \(opens in a new window\)](#).

Apply and further information

This vacancy is part of the [Great Place to Work for Veterans \(opens in a new window\)](#) initiative.

Once this job has closed, the job advert will no longer be available. You may want to save a copy for your records.

Contact point for applicants

Job contact :

Name : DDT Capability Based Pay team

Email : pay-capability.ddat@education.gov.uk

Recruitment team

Email : Centralrecruitment.operations@education.gov.uk

Further information

The Department for Education's recruitment processes are underpinned by the Civil Service Commissioners Recruitment Principles, which outlines that selection for appointment is made on merit based on fair and open competition. You have the right to complain if you feel a department has breached the requirement of the Recruitment Principles. In the first instance, you should raise the matter directly with the department concerned via CentralRecruitment.Operations@education.gov.uk. If you are not satisfied with the response, you may bring your complaint to the Commission. For further information on bringing a complaint to the Civil Service Commission please visit their [web pages](#)

